Comparative Politics

POLC-2300-01

Prof. Gustavo Diaz

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About me

Pronouns: He/him

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Ok to address me as:

- Prof. Diaz
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- First name

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About this course

An introduction to **comparative politics**

- A subfield of political science
- Also a methodological approach

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Yes, no, maybe?, it's complicated...
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What is comparative politics?

Old definition

Comparative Politics and the Comparative Method*

AREND LIJPHART
University of Leiden

Among the several fields or subdisciplines into which the discipline of political science is usually divided, comparative politics is the only one that carries a methodological instead of a substantive label. The term "comparative politics" indicates the *how* but does not specify the *what* of the analysis. The label is somewhat misleading because both explicit methodological concern and implicit methodological aware-

In the literature of comparative politics, a wide variety of meanings is attached to the terms "comparison" and "comparative method." The comparative method is defined here as one of the basic methods—the others being the experimental, statistical, and case study methods—of establishing general empirical propositions. It is, in the first place, definitely a *method*, not just "a convenient term

What is comparative politics?

The problem with this definition

1. **Methodological pluralism:** Comparativists today use experiments, statistics, case studies, and many more methods

2. **Science** is all about *making comparisons*

Why was this the predominant view?

What is comparative politics?

Some history

- **Cold War:** Geopolitical incentives to *understand* and *classify* countries
- Neither **American Politics** nor **International Relations**
- **Academics:** Try to make sense of the *everything else* category

What is comparative politics?

Current definition

American politics	*Domestic politics*
International relations	*Politics among nations*
Comparative politics	*Politics within (other) nations*

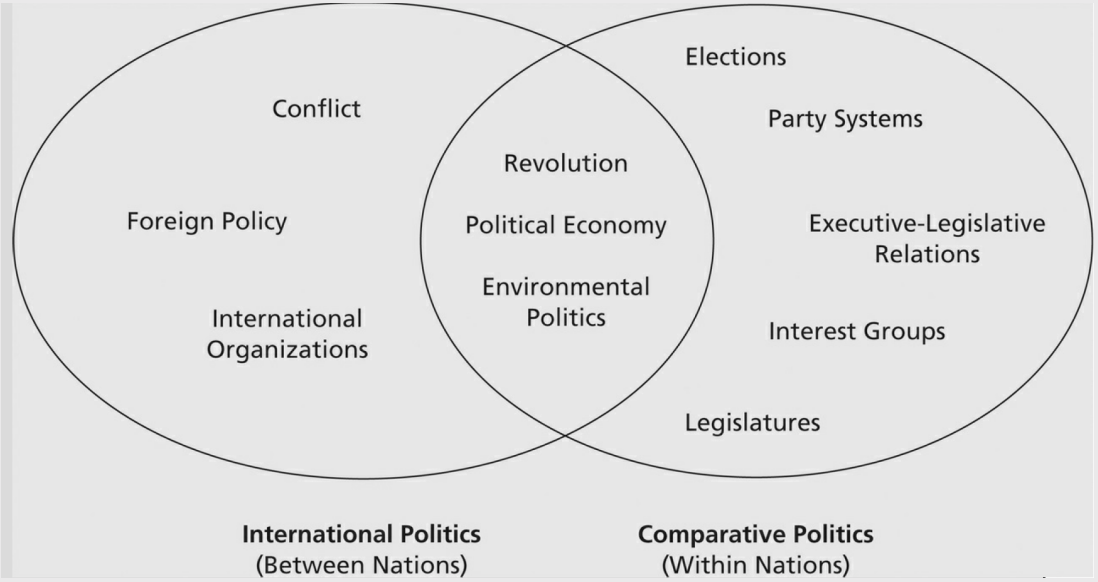
But...

- Outside of the U.S. $\rightarrow$ `AP = CP`
- IR and CP not mutually exclusive `(e.g. audience costs)`

What is comparative politics?

Course definition

Comparative politics is the study of politics *predominantly* **within countries**



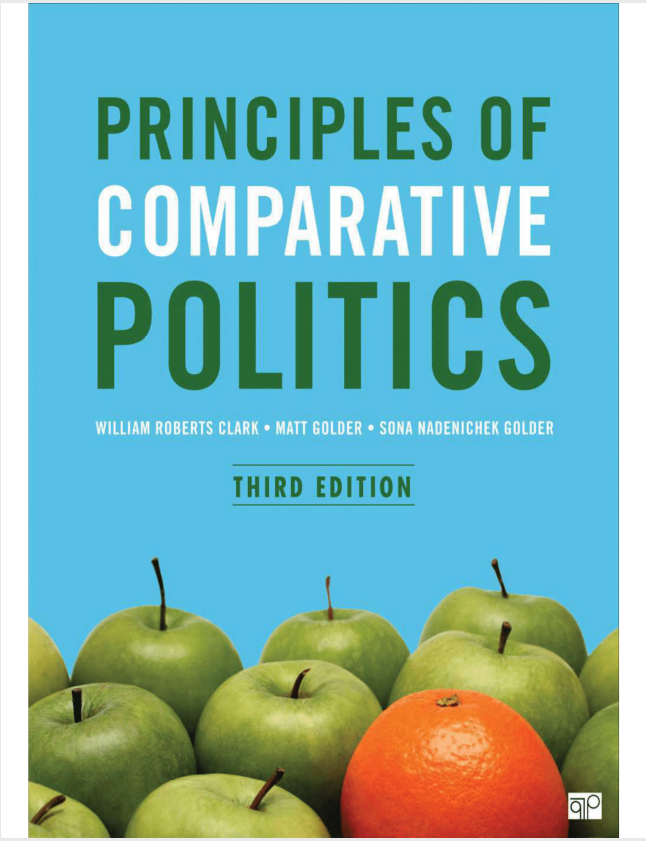
Course roadmap

1. What is comparative politics?
2. Origins of political systems (nation-states, governments, regime types)
3. Causes and consequences of regime types
4. Varieties of democracies and dictatorships

Course Requirements

Requirements

Textbook



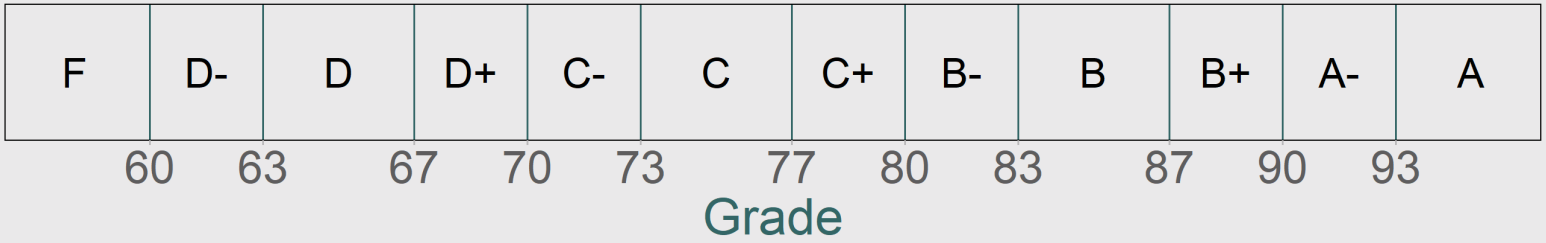
Requirements

Assignments

Assignment	Percentage
Quizzes (6)	40%
News Reports (6)	40%
Participation	20%
Final Exam	30% of final grade

Requirements

Grading



- **Decimal grades** truncated to largest integer `(92.1 = 93)`
- **Grades at the limit** get the highest letter grade `(93 = A)`

Important dates

Assignment	Date
Quiz 1	September 3
News Report 1	September 10
Quiz 2	September 17
News Report 2	September 24
Quiz 3	October 1
Fall Break (NO CLASS)	October 4-8
News Report 3	October 15
Quiz 4	October 22
News Report 4	October 29
Quiz 5	November 5
News Report 5	November 12
Thanksgiving Break (NO CLASS)	November 22-26
Quiz 6	December 3
News Report 6	December 10
Final Exam	TBD

Thursday:

What is Science?